From Private Servants to Systemic Problems:

the Shifting Goals of Satire of Wives

*** *** 人文科学试验班

Maggie Trinkle's 2020 essay, *I (Don't) Want a Wife*, parodies Judy Brady's 1971 essay to critique women's unpaid labor as a systemic failure rather than a domestic duty. While mirroring Brady's repetitive "I want" syntax, Trinkle's satire diverges by targeting a broader social system.

Trinkle employs verbal irony through the parentheses around "don't" in her title to create a contradiction, thus forming a qualified echo of Brady's original essay. The contrast reflects the paradox of women: they are expected to do the work, yet denied recognition, suggesting that these problems should not be solved by wives alone. Furthermore, her overstatement of the "fourth shift" exaggerates women's already overloaded unpaid labor. Sterilizing groceries and burning boxes show how women's labor seems to have no limits, making it absurd that they are expected to become "experts" against the pandemic overnight.

They both expose how wives are treated as unrecognized, exploited labor by using the phrase "want," despite a fifty-year gap. However, the pandemic-era context shifts the focus significantly, where wives are expected to serve not only their own families but also society as a whole. Trinkle goes further than Brady: she critiques a society that forces wives to shoulder its responsibilities. Thus, their aims differ: Brady wants an equal relationship and a respectful home, but Trinkle points to a society that continues to rely on women's unpaid labor. This suggests that such a logic is structurally dependent on women's unpaid labor, which reveals its inherent inequality.

In summary, both essays critique the unfair expectations placed on wives by making plain, domestic life seem ridiculous. By parodying Brady, Trinkle extends the critique beyond the home to the broader system. Nevertheless, the two essays together show how satire can expose the absurdity of expecting wives to absorb endless labor without recognition.